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The emotions of the crowd were indescribable. Women were hysterical, scores fainted; men wept.

Louis Waldman

**Eyewitness to the Triangle
Shirtwaist Factory fire (1892–1982)**

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Those employees on the top floor, the tenth, made their way to the roof and to safety. Among them were Blanck and Harris. However, those on the eighth and ninth floors had no means of escape. Only one of the two small elevators was in use, and it could carry no more than 12 people at a time. After just three trips, it broke down.

There were two staircases, one leading to Greene Street, the other to Washington Place. Many people escaped to the roof via the former before the fire made it impassable. The Washington Place stairs were accessible but led to a locked door. A pile of bodies was later found behind it. The fire escape was equally useless—it buckled and disintegrated, causing 20 workers to fall to their death.

Those who were still trapped inside faced being burned alive or dying from smoke inhalation. To the horror of the crowds below, 62 sought a more desperate end still, throwing themselves to their

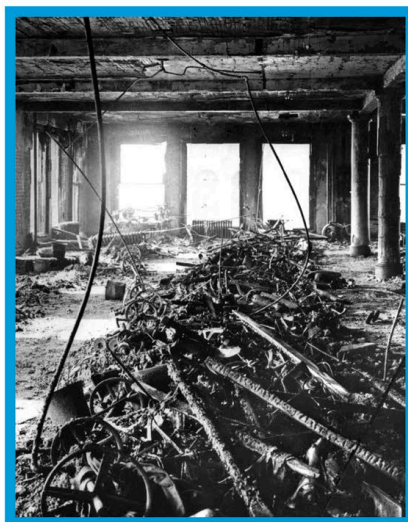
The fire at the factory destroyed much of the interior of the Asch Building. The youngest victims of the blaze were two teenaged girls who were both aged just 14.

deaths from windows in the blazing upper stories. Several of them were on fire as they jumped, and many were seen to hold hands before leaping. Thirty-six also died after plunging down the elevator shafts in a no-less-futile attempt at escape.

The city's fire services were helpless. Although almost every fireman in the city came racing to the building, their largest ladders could reach only to the sixth floor and their most powerful hoses not much higher. Nets were stretched out to catch the falling and jumping workers, but they split apart from the pressure of the impact.

Public reaction

In December 1911, Blanck and Harris were tried for manslaughter but were acquitted, largely on technicalities. Their counsel, not denying that the Washington Place door was locked, successfully argued that there was no proof that the defendants knew the door was locked. In 1913, the families of the dead launched a civil suit, charging Blanck and Harris with causing “wrongful death.” They succeeded only to the extent that compensation of \$75 was awarded



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I know from my experience it is up to the working people to save themselves.

Rose Schneiderman

**Trade union activist
(1882–1972)**

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to each family. In the meantime, Blanck and Harris had already received an insurance payout of about \$60,000 to help cover their “loss of revenue.”

The fire burned for hardly 30 minutes, yet its social and political impact was enormous, despite the fact that Blanck and Harris later cleared their names. On April 5, 1911, a vast rally, estimated to have been 100,000 strong, marched through New York demanding improved working conditions. It was watched by a silent crowd of 400,000 people. Public outrage among all classes was palpable. In June 1911, the New York State Legislature sanctioned the creation of the Factory Investigating Commission, and an immense raft of reforms and recommendations followed.

Almost no kind of industrialized business escaped the commission's stringent recommendations, and chemical factories in particular were singled out. Among the most lasting reforms was the Sullivan-Hoey Fire Prevention Law, which made sprinkler systems compulsory and led to vastly improved means of access and exit, with all doors having to open outward rather than inward.